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Blog

Georgia Becomes a National Solar Leader

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As a seemingly unlikely candidate for a national solar power leader, Georgia finds itself in an unusual intersection between geography and bipartisan political forces. Georgia's climate and the uncommon alliance between the state's liberals and tea party conservatives make it a fertile spot for rapid solar industry growth.

Georgia Public Service Commissioner Tim Echols recently noted that Georgia is the fastest growing solar state in America. He cited research released last November by the Pew Charitable Trusts confirming that "State and federal policies have helped to make the Peach State the fastest-growing solar market (<http://bit.ly/1l6oVXt>) in the country."

Emerging Bipartisan Legislation

Other than the abundant sunshine Georgia receives, there is bipartisan solar support locally and in Washington. Recently, State Representative Mike Dudgeon (R) drafted legislation (<http://bit.ly/1xmyNLV>) to help property owners mitigate the upfront cost of installing solar panel systems in Georgia.

"It's been an adventure (<http://bit.ly/1BEYEtz>)," Dudgeon said in reference to the tumultuous journey of crafting the potential law.

Currently “Residential and commercial property owners in Georgia can install solar panels under current law. However, with no third-party financing allowed, they must pay the installer up front,” says Dave Williams of the Atlanta Business Chronicle. Dudgeon’s proposed legislation would make it legal to seek third-party financing.

For those unfamiliar with the process, Solar Energy Industries Association offers (<http://bit.ly/199GsS8>) the distinction between the two models of third-party financing for a solar energy system:

“A customer can sign a traditional lease and pay for the use of a solar system or the customer can sign a power purchase agreements (PPA) to pay a specific rate for the electricity that is generated each month.”

This legislation’s bipartisan support could be due to the intersection between environmental concern and free market interests. One side may be rooting for solar due to the decreased dependence on fossil fuels, while the other may be championing the free market disruption of the utility company monopolies.

Of course, members of state and federal government may have their own mix of reasons. What remains is a fertile common ground that may springboard the solar generated energy market into the mainstream.

Dropping Costs

The legislation easing the burden of upfront costs on property owners pairs with plummeting costs of the hardware itself. Robert Rentfrow, senior vice president for power supply at Walton Electric Membership Corporation noted that the cost for equipment continues to fall.

And now that China has increased its investment in renewables by 32% last year (<http://bloom.bg/1MR1cx5>), the solar power generating equipment is “dirt cheap (<http://bit.ly/1HbS8m4>),” Rentfrow said. He adds that the consensus of Georgia’s power companies creates certainty that “solar power is going to become an important part of our mix.”

Takeaway

Surprising as it may be, Georgia is leading the nation with expanding the solar power market. The Peach State benefits from a unique mix of ample sun, bipartisan support, eager private and public businesses, and a continually decreasing cost of ownership.

Phyllis Cuttino, director of Pew’s clean energy initiative concludes (<http://bit.ly/1I6oVXt>) with the positive impact this news has on Georgia’s job market. “The state is now realizing the economic benefits of renewable power, including solar jobs, which grew 225 percent last year to 2,600—the largest gain of any state,” she said.

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